

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 845

By Hakeem

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Representative Tommie F. Brown of Chattanooga.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of our friend and former colleague Representative Tommie F. Brown of Chattanooga; and

WHEREAS, a courageous community leader who left her mark on the political landscape of both Chattanooga and the State of Tennessee, Representative Tommie Brown faithfully and honorably served the people of Hamilton County's 28th House District as a member of the 98th, 99th, 100th, 101st, 102nd, 103rd, 104th, 105th, 106th, and 107th General Assemblies; and

WHEREAS, a trailblazing professional in higher education, Dr. Tommie Brown earned a Bachelor of Arts degree from B.A. Dillard University, a Master of Social Work degree from Washington University, and a Doctorate of Social Work from Columbia University; and

WHEREAS, in 1971, Dr. Brown joined the faculty at the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga, where she founded the Social Work program and later became the first African-American woman to serve as a department head; for decades she shaped minds and hearts, training generations of social workers, mentors, and leaders who would carry forward her belief that knowledge is power and service is a duty; and

WHEREAS, putting her beliefs in action, Representative Brown was the lead plaintiff in *Brown v. City of Chattanooga*, and she stood unwavering in the fight against an at-large election system that had long diluted Black voting power; this effort transformed Chattanooga's government into a mayor–council system with district-based elections, finally ensuring that communities of color had representation; and

WHEREAS, as a member of the General Assembly, she sponsored legislation addressing education, health, racial discrimination, children's rights, and voting rights; she also helped organize community efforts and civic leadership networks across the State; and

WHEREAS, Representative Brown was among the individuals who called for a complete overhaul of Tennessee's foster care system, demanding better health care and services for children in state custody, and her efforts led to the history and contributions of Tennessee's first African-American legislators being preserved by the Tennessee State Library and Archives and made available online; and

WHEREAS, Representative Brown served with impeccable statesmanship throughout her legislative tenure, during which she rendered sterling service as a member of the House State and Local Government Committee; House Finance, Ways and Means Committee; House General Subcommittee of the State and Local Committee; House and Senate Joint Fiscal Review Committee; House Calendar and Rules Committee; House Children and Family Affairs Committee; House K-12 Subcommittee; House Education Special Initiatives Subcommittee; House Domestic Relations Subcommittee; House and Senate Joint Education Oversight Subcommittee; Joint Select Committee on Children and Youth; Joint Select Committee on Pensions and Insurance; Joint Lottery Scholarship Committee; Diabetes Prevention Study Committee; and Title VI Compliance Review Commission; and

WHEREAS, respected for her leadership abilities, Representative Brown was chosen to serve as the vice chair of the House Education Committee, the chair of the House Higher Education Subcommittee, and the chair of the Tennessee Black Caucus of State Legislators; and

WHEREAS, a highly-valued member of her community, Representative Brown dedicated her time and energies to a number of civic organizations and endeavors, including the Chattanooga Chapter of the National Political Congress of Black Women, which she co-founded; the Hamilton County Democratic Women's Club; the Pi Omega Chapter of the Alpha Kappa Alpha Sorority; the Education Equal Opportunity Group, Inc., for which she served as a

board member; and the Southeast Tennessee Development District, for which she served as an executive board member; and

WHEREAS, in 2002, Hamilton County Schools named a school in her honor, the Dr. Tommie F. Brown Academy for Classical Studies; and

WHEREAS, after her retirement from public service, Representative Brown remained active by advocating for issues that uplifted her community, helping build coalitions to address pressing issues, and continuing to mentor the leaders of tomorrow; and

WHEREAS, Representative Tommie Brown's legacy is living proof that courage and dedication can reshape institutions, lift communities, and make the world better a better place than we found it. She leaves a city that is more just, a state that is more accountable, and a history that will preserve the work of a woman who devoted her life to service; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Tommie F. Brown, reflecting fondly upon her legacy of service to the people of Tennessee and her stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Representative Brown.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.